

START_HERE_PLAIN

Start Here — In Plain English

Plain-language companion to `START_HERE.md`. For the exact spec, read that / its PDF.

In one sentence

This is the map of the whole repo: it tells you which handful of files to actually open, what to ignore, and what you should have built by the end of four weeks.

Why this matters to you

The repo has a lot of documents and almost no code. It is very easy to drown in reading and never start building. This file is the antidote: it points you at the five docs that matter, keeps six open as reference, and tells you to ignore everything else until a milestone forces you to look. Read it once and you stop feeling lost.

The big ideas, simply

- **The repo is two layers.** Layer A is the plan and spec — about 25 documents, basically finished. Layer B is the code — empty folders like `dbt/`, `mcp/`, `agents/`. Your whole job is turning A into B.
- **You don't read everything.** Read 5 docs once, keep ~6 open as reference, ignore the rest.
- **You copy, you don't invent.** The docs already contain the code. You adapt it; you never make up new SQL or metrics. (This also keeps the Claude Pro bill low.)
- **Two front doors.** `START_HERE.md` (this) is the map and week plan. `HELIOS_EXECUTION_GUIDE.md` is the detailed daily playbook. Use this to orient, that to execute.
- **CLAUDE.md is always on.** It auto-loads into every Claude Code session, so the rules and canonical names are always in context. You don't open it; it's just there.

What you actually do (in order)

1. **Tonight (pre-M0 → M0):** Go to `HELIOS_EXECUTION_GUIDE.md` Part 5. Create the four dbt config files from `DBT_GUIDE.md` §1, connect to BigQuery, and get `dbt debug` green plus one small test query returning rows. That's the whole job for tonight.
2. **Week 1 (M0–M4):** Build the dbt data tables (`fct_funnel` , `fct_daily_funnel` , `fct_orders` , plus dimension tables). Done when `dbt build` is green, revenue matches to the cent, the funnel is monotonic, and channels equal exactly 10.
3. **Week 2 (M5 + decomposition):** Turn on the metric registry and build the mix-vs-rate engine (`decompose_change`). Done when the validator finds 0 dangling refs, the golden test passes, and one funnel move is diagnosed and priced.
4. **Week 3 (M6 + M7):** Wire one MCP server to Claude and produce a grounded Decision Brief. Done when queries round-trip and every number traces to a tool output (0 hallucinated columns).
5. **Week 4 (M10 + writeup):** Run 6–10 labeled scenarios against a naive baseline. Done when Helios beats the baseline and the whole loop runs from one command.

The daily rhythm: open the playbook at your milestone, copy the code from the architecture doc it cites, write the test, run it yourself, paste the real output, tick the tracker, commit, `/clear` , repeat.

Easy things to get wrong

- **Reading too much.** The number one failure mode is documentation overload. Cap reading and start coding.
- **Writing a model before M0 works.** You can't run anything until dbt talks to BigQuery. Do M0 first.
- **Building cut-line items.** The 7-agent fleet, the Critic loop, memory, the scheduler, the other 4 MCP servers, the frontend — none of these belong in the 4-week build.
- **Reading the Bible cover to cover.** It's 233 KB. Jump to a numbered section only when a smaller doc can't answer you.
- **Inventing code.** If it's not in a doc, you're probably drifting. Copy and adapt.

Glossary — the exact words, demystified

- **M0–M12** — the 13 milestones, in build order. M0 is setup; M12 is far-future production.
- **dbt** — the tool that turns your SQL files into governed BigQuery tables.
- **marts** — the final, clean tables you build (`fct_*` , `dim_*`).

- **monotonic funnel** — each funnel step has fewer or equal sessions than the one before, so step rates never exceed 1.
- **semantic_layer.yaml** — the registry: the single list of approved metrics and their SQL.
- **MCP server** — a small service that gives the LLM safe, governed tools (instead of letting it write raw SQL).
- **Decision Brief** — the final output: a short report explaining a funnel move, priced in dollars.
- **hallucinated column** — a made-up table/column name; the target is zero of these.

When to open the real doc

Open `START_HERE.md` (and its copy under `pdf/`) whenever you lose the thread of what to build next, or need the full file index. For the exact first task, jump to `HELIOS_EXECUTION_GUIDE.md` Part 5.